InsideOut

PROJECT PROPOSAL · 2026

Wisdom Wheels

An intergenerational model for reducing loneliness, strengthening integration and building social sustainability.

non-profit
association
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Introduction.

Project Proposal: Wisdom Wheels — an intergenerational model for reducing loneliness, strengthening integration and building social sustainability.

Gothenburg has around 580,000 inhabitants, of whom roughly 20 per cent are over 65. That means more than 110,000 people are in a life stage where social networks often shrink. Many of them live alone, and a significant share have limited daily social contact.

National research shows that between 20 and 30 per cent of older adults regularly experience loneliness. Social isolation is in turn strongly linked to depression, poorer physical health and increased mortality. Loneliness is today regarded as one of the most serious — yet least visible — public health challenges.

Gothenburg is also marked by clear socio-economic and geographical segregation. Around 30 per cent of the city's inhabitants have a non-Swedish background, and in certain neighbourhoods the share is considerably higher.

Many newcomers and young people in these areas lack established networks in the majority society, have limited opportunities for language practice in real-life contexts, and experience a social and cultural distance from other groups.

This leads to a situation where different groups live parallel lives, with few natural points of encounter.

Purpose.

To reduce loneliness and strengthen social cohesion through meaningful encounters between generations and life experiences

Wisdom Wheels is a social innovation project addressing two of the most pressing societal challenges of our time: the growing loneliness among older adults and the increasing segregation in society.

The project aims to create meaningful, structured and recurring encounters between older people in care or social isolation and young people and newcomers in the establishment phase. Through a method that combines physical activity, guided experiences, conversation and shared meals, a platform is created where people not only meet — but also develop relationships, understanding and a sense of belonging.

The project is carried out in Gothenburg over a period of 18 months and aims to establish an evidence-based, scalable model that can be implemented in other municipalities.

01 Reduces experienced loneliness and mental ill-health among older adults

02 Strengthens integration, language and participation among newcomers

03 Creates long-term relationships between generations

04 Contributes to a more cohesive and inclusive society

Project Goals.

Project Goals (18 months)

100+
older participants

60+
young & newcomer pilots

50+
structured activities

1
documented method

Outcomes

The project will lead to:

· Reduced experienced loneliness among participating older adults

· Increased sense of meaning and quality of life

· Improved language and social skills among newcomers

· New social networks across generational and cultural boundaries

Link to Agenda 2030

Wisdom Wheels addresses these goals by creating concrete, local solutions that strengthen social sustainability.

- goal 3 Good health
- goal 10 Reduced inequality
- goal 11 Sustainable cities

Labour Market Perspective

The project helps create pathways towards further engagement and employment for young people and newcomers. By participating as bicycle pilots, participants gain practical experience, develop a sense of responsibility and strengthen their language and social skills through real-life encounters. The initiative functions as a learning environment where skills relevant to working life are developed, while participants gain an active and meaningful role in society.

Context Analysis.

In Sweden there is an initiative that partly addresses elements of this issue. The most prominent is Cycling Without Age, which offers bicycle rides for older adults through volunteer efforts. These initiatives have shown positive effects on quality of life and wellbeing.

InsideOut views this type of work positively and intends to explore opportunities for dialogue and collaboration with existing actors where possible and relevant. At the same time, the current situation suggests that activity in Gothenburg is limited.

STRUCTURAL LIMITATIONS

1. Focus on activity rather than relationship
2. Lack of reciprocity
3. Absence of an integration perspective
4. Limited methodology and structure
5. Weaker connection to long-term societal impact

Wisdom Wheels builds on these initiatives but develops the model into an integrated social intervention, where the encounter between people is at the core.

Encounters that build relationships, understanding and belonging — across generations, cultures and life experiences.

Execution.

Access to the project's target groups is ensured through established partnerships with both public actors and civil society. Older participants are primarily reached via care homes, home care services and needs assessors.

Young and newly arrived participants are reached through collaboration with SFI programmes, integration initiatives and local associations and youth organisations. The organisation currently reaches over 200 families in need of social and inclusive interventions.

Organisation and Competence

The project is led by a project manager with overall responsibility for planning, execution and coordination. The programme developer is responsible for method, content and quality of activities, while the communications lead works with recruitment, outreach and documentation.

Follow-up and Evaluation

The project is monitored through a combination of quantitative and qualitative methods to ensure both measurable results and a deeper understanding of participants' experiences. Qualitative methods such as interviews and documentation are used to capture participants'experiences.

Method.

The project's method rests on three parts that together create the conditions for meaningful encounters — movement, reflection and the shared meal.

i Mobile meeting place → ii Structured content → iii Shared meal

i · method

Mobile meeting place.

At the core of the project are the guided bicycle rides, where older participants have the opportunity to leave their everyday environment and experience the city in an accessible and safe way. Participants travel in specially adapted cargo bikes that enable comfort, safety and presence in the experience.

Young people and newcomers are trained as bicycle pilots and guides. Their role is not merely to transport, but to be active co-creators of the experience by guiding, initiating conversations and creating safety in the encounter.

ii · method

Structured content.

To ensure that the encounters gain depth and quality, each activity is complemented by structured pedagogical content. This is developed within the project and consists of conversation materials, thematic frameworks and reflection-based tools.

The aim is to create conditions for conversations that go beyond superficial interactions and instead enable genuine exchange of experience. By combining structure with openness, a safe framework is created where participants can share perspectives, memories and thoughts.

iii · method

Shared meal.

Each activity concludes with a shared meal, which forms a central part of the methodology. The meal functions as a space for social deepening where relationships can develop further in a calm and inclusive environment.

During the meal, conversations are facilitated based on the themes introduced during the activity. Participants are given space to reflect on the experience, share stories and listen to one another. The meal helps create a sense of community and belonging, where all participants are seen as equals.

The method's three parts form a coherent whole — from movement and experience, through deepening, to community.

i → ii → iii

Thank you.

"We are many voices, many professions and many journeys — united in the conviction that healing begins from within. Let us join our forces and together create a world built on resilience, compassion and human potential"

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